

Hotel frontline service employees' creativity and customer-oriented boundary-spanning behaviors: The effects of role stress and proactive personality

Shih-Yi Chien, Albert Jing-Fuh Yang^{*}, Yung-Chin Huang

Department of Marketing and Distribution Management, National Kaohsiung University of Science and Technology, 1 University Road, Yanchao District, Kaohsiung City, 824, Taiwan

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ABSTRACT

The current study examined the relationships among role stress, proactive personality, employee creativity, and customer-oriented boundary spanning behaviors (COBSBs) for frontline service employees (FSEs). This study collected data from 382 FSEs in international hotels in Taiwan to test the research model. The empirical results revealed that employee creativity was positively affected by proactive personality but negatively affected by role conflict and role ambiguity. FSEs' creativity positively affects COBSBs, including external representation, internal influence, and service delivery. Internal influence also positively affects service delivery and mediates the relationship between FSEs' creativity and service delivery.

1. Introduction

Creativity, which involves the generation of useful and novel ideas for the birth of new products and services (Akgunduz, Alkan, & Gö). The hospitality industry is a customer-oriented service industry involving frequent interactions between customers and frontline service employees (FSEs). FSEs, by dealing with customers' requirements and collecting first-hand information of customer service, are in an optimal position to generate creative ideas to improve the customer service offered (Ruiz-Palomino & Zoghbi-Manrique-de-Lara, 2020; Wang, Wen, Pasamehmetoğlu, & Guchait, 2021). The crucial role of FSEs' creativity in hotel service has been recognized by researchers and practitioners (e.g. Wang, Wen, Pasamehmetoğlu, & Guchait, 2021).

With increasing competition, FSEs' creativity becomes a source of competitive advantages because using creative ideas can rapidly solve customers' problems, delight customers and then to enhance service quality and customer satisfaction. Here is a story of how two FSEs, work at Dove Mountain Resort, use creative ideas to solve customers' problem as follows (Solomon, 2017). While a guest family packed up to leave for an airport, they found that their son lost his favorite Thomas toy. Without the permission from management, the two FSEs purchased a Thomas toy and composed a tale about how a Thomas toy extended vacation, including adorable pictures of Thomas exploring Dove

Mountain Resort. And then the gift of Thomas toy with the note arrived by FedEx at the guest family.

FSEs are viewed as boundary-spanning workers with responsibilities to both internal (managers and co-workers) and external (customers) entities (Agnihotri, Rapp, Andzulis, & Gabler, 2014). FSEs' creativity may provide excellence service delivery to enhance customer satisfaction, increase impressions toward the company, and internally share their creative ideas with co-workers (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Chang & Teng, 2017; Kim, Hon, & Lee, 2010). In view to this, FSEs' creativity may simultaneously provide benefits to customers, co-workers, and managers.

Previous research on employees' behavior role behavior at the FSEs' level includes in-role and extra-role behavior. Especially, extra-role behavior is also viewed as organizational citizenship behavior (OCB) (Scheepers & Van der Borgh, 2020). The hospitality literature has discussed various OCBs, but the OCBs are not simultaneously directed to the organization, co-workers, and customers. For example, traditional OCBs are directed to the organization itself (e.g. Kim, McGinley, Choi, & Agmapisarn, 2020), interpersonal citizenship behaviors are directed to the co-worker itself (e.g. Khelifat, Chen, Ayoun, & Eyoun, 2021), customer-oriented citizenship behaviors (e.g. Garba, Babalolab, & Guo, 2018) or service-oriented citizenship behaviors (e.g. Kloutsiniotis & Mihail, 2020) are directed to the customer itself. Due to the FSEs' role of

^{*} Corresponding author.

E-mail addresses: shihyi@nkust.edu.tw (S.-Y. Chien), jfyang@nkust.edu.tw (A.-J.-F. Yang), yung.chinh@msa.hinet.net (Y.-C. Huang).

boundary spanners, the current study focuses on the concept of customer-oriented boundary spanning behaviors (COBSBs), which the behaviors are directed to the organization, co-workers, and customers. According to Bettencourt and Brown (2003), enhancing COBSBs is a promising avenue for FSEs' seeking to achieve excellence in three aspects: external representation, internal influence, and service delivery. That means that external representation refers to present a positive impression of the company; internal influence refers to internally share a creative idea with co-workers and superiors; service delivery refers to provide service based on job descriptions.

Since FSEs delivery customer service in their role as boundary spanning, the need to interact with a wider set of customers, co-workers, and superiors who have various demands and expectations may allow them to experience high level of role stress (Hodari, Waldthausen, & Sturman, 2014; Grobelna, 2015). FSEs may follow job descriptions to perform standardized operational routine tasks to meet customer requirements. However, because service production and consumption are performed in the dynamic process of customer-FSE interaction, FSEs are often asked to meet the uncertain needs of customers without a clear standard, even deviate from the standard service procedure (Wang et al., 2021). On the other hand, since FSEs often take on multiple roles in conflict as boundary spanners of both the company's and customer's interests (Kim, Murrmann, Lee, Kim, 2009), they receive incompatible job demands from customers, co-workers, and superiors, but are not able to satisfy all their demands simultaneously (Karatepe, 2010). The contradictory and conflict inherent to boundary-spanning FSEs results role ambiguity and role conflict (Hodari et al., 2014), which generate the depletion of energy and then impede their generation of creative ideas (Hon, Chan, & Lu, 2013). Prior research suggests that role ambiguity and role conflict negatively affect employee creativity (Eatough, Chang, Miloslavic, & Johnson, 2011).

Since services are produced by means of employees' personal interactions with customers, employee creativity is attributed to personality traits (Shalley, Zhou, & Oldham, 2004; Akgunduz et al., 2018). Proactive personality is described as one who is likely to equip capabilities of showing initiatives, taking actions, and identifying opportunities (Hornig, Tsai, Hu, & Liu, 2016). While responding to uncertain customer needs and requests, passive employees may follow routine standard operations, but proactive employees tend to find opportunities to make changes in the standard operation and then seek new and better solutions (Alikaj, Ning, & Wu, 2020). Companies that wish to emphasize creativity may be more successful if they hire and retain individuals with proactive personality (Kim, Hon, & Crant, 2009).

In summary, the outcomes of FSEs creativity may provide benefits to the organization, co-workers, and customers, hotel organizations may need to understand how the key factors obstruct and facilitate FSE creativity. Prior research suggest that individual (e.g., affective or cognitive states, and individual personality) and contextual (e.g., work environment) factors affect the development of creativity (Amabile, Conti, Coon, Lazenby, & Herron, 1996). Based on the job demands-resources (JD-R), job demands decrease employee well-being, but job resources increase employee well-being (Bakker & Demerouti, 2007). Creativity-related studies in the hotel industry argued that hindrance stressors as work demands negatively affect employee creativity (Hon et al., 2013), but personal traits, such as proactive personality as personal resources positively affect employee creativity (Hornig et al., 2016). Despite the importance of understanding how role stress and proactive personality affect employee creativity, empirical research has yet to identify the relationships among role ambiguity, role conflict, proactive personality, and FSEs' creativity.

The current study aims to provide two significant contributions. First, we explore how FSEs' creativity as a trigger facilitates the development of COBSBs. Prior research in the hospitality industry revealed that employee creativity generates positive performance, such as including employee job performance (e.g. Chang & Teng, 2017), customer satisfaction (e.g. Wang et al., 2021), hotel performance (e.g.

Dabrowski, Brzozowska-Woś, Gołab-Andrzejak, & Firgolska, 2019). However, these concepts view the organization or its employees rather than customers as the beneficiary of discretionary behavior (Schepers & Van der Borgh, 2020), few research proposes customer-oriented OCB that are assumed to be beneficial to not only organizations and its employees, but also to customers (Jung & Yoon, 2020). The current study focuses on COBSBs to engage in exploring how creativity affects external representation, internal influence, and service delivery. Furthermore, the current study examines how internal influence mediates the relationship between creativity and service delivery. Second, few studies have examined how both role stress and proactive personality affect employee creativity (Liu & Shi, 2014), especially in the hospitality industry. Hon and Lui (2016) reviewed creativity-related studies in the hospitality industry and noted that job stress and unwillingness to change are critical determinants hindering employee creativity in the workplace. With the ongoing debates on the JD-R as a backdrop, we propose a broader perspective of what obstructs and facilitates of FSEs' creativity by simultaneously investigating the negative effect of role ambiguity and role conflict and the positive effect of proactive personality.

For this study, a survey was conducted of 382 FSEs working in international hotels in Taiwan in the Fall of 2019. The number of foreign tourists visiting Taiwan hit a record high in 2019 (Huang, 2020) and the importance of international hotels is evident. In 2019, there were 79 international hotels in Taiwan catering for foreign nationals, with a total of 21,968 rooms, but only 48 local hotels, providing just 6,922 rooms (Tourism Bureau, 2019). It is thus imperative for hotels to cultivate employee creativity and promote COBSBs if they are to satisfy these visitors.

2. Literature review and hypotheses development

According to Amabile et al. (1996) creativity can be defined as the process of generating useful and new ideas with regard to practices, procedures, services, or products for an organization. In the service context, FSEs are an important source of employee creativity because they are the people tasked with identifying customer needs, dealing with more challenging tasks, solving service problems creatively, and delivering a customized service (Coelho, Augusto, & Lages, 2011). Employee creativity can generate positive outcomes for individuals and firms, including innovation (Slåtten, Svensson, &), career success (Kim, Hon, & Crant, 2009), high job performance (Agnihotri et al., 2014; Chang & Teng, 2017), and new service development (Yang, Lee, & Cheng, 2016).

According to the job demands-resources (JD-R) model, work characteristics can be classified in terms of two categories, namely job demands and job resources, both of which are relevant to employee well-being (Bakker & Demerouti, 2007). Job demands incur physiological or psychological costs, while job resources reduce job demands and achieve work goals. This contrasts with the two assumptions of conservation of resources (COR): (1) the primacy of resource loss, where efforts are made to protect these resources, and (2) resource investment, where resources are invested to gain additional resources (Hobfoll, Halbesleben, Neveu, & Westman, 2018). Combining resource investment with the motivational aspect of job resources, Xanthopoulou, Bakker, Demerouti, and Schaufeli (2007) suggested that personal resources can lead to an accumulation of resources that subsequently improve positive outcomes. Based on the above concepts, role stress is considered to arise from job demands that lead to resource depletion, and a proactive personality is a willingness to invest job resources to support goal achievement.

Previous research on employees' role behavior can be classified as examining in-role behavior and extra-role behavior (Schepers & Van der Borgh, 2020). In-role behavior refers to fulfill the formally required tasks to meet organizational standards, and also be viewed as role-prescribed behavior (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003). Extra-role concerns discretionary behaviors that go beyond job requirements, and also

be viewed as traditional organizational citizenship behavior (Scheper & Van der Borgh, 2020). However, Bettencourt and Brown (1997) indicate that in-role and extra-role behaviors cannot completely explore the role of cooperative behaviors among FSEs and other employees of the company. While FSEs as boundary spanners deliver exceptional service to customers, they often need the cooperative behaviors from co-workers or supervisors (Bettencourt & Brown, 1997). Customer orientation, which is based on relationship marketing, refers to an employee's tendency to fulfill customers' needs and increase their satisfaction (Saxe & Weitz, 1982). Combining the service marketing/management and boundary-spanning literatures, Bettencourt and Brown (2003) focus on customer-linking behaviors of FSEs to propose customer-oriented boundary spanning behaviors (COBSBs), including external representation, internal influence, and service delivery.

2.1. Role conflict, role ambiguity, and employee creativity

Role stress tends to be generated when the expected and perceived roles differ (Hartenian, Hadaway, & Badovick, 1994). Role stress includes role ambiguity, role conflict, and role overload. In the challenge stressor–hindrance stressor framework, compared to role overload as a challenge stressor, both role ambiguity and role conflict are viewed as hindrance-related stressors (Akinola, Kapadia, Lu, & Mason, 2019).

Role conflict and role ambiguity are the two major types of role stress. Role conflict refers to incompatible job expectations and can originate from multiple roles or a single role (Dubinsky & Skinner, 1984), while role ambiguity is caused by a lack of knowledge and information on how to execute the job correctly (Dubinsky & Mattson, 1979). Perhaps not surprisingly, role conflict and role ambiguity are negatively related to work outcomes, typically by reducing organizational commitment, job satisfaction, and work involvement (Eatough et al., 2011).

According to the principle of COR (Hobfoll, 1989; Hobfoll et al., 2018), when FSEs are under stressful situations, in order to minimize resource loss, they might not be willing to give additional energy and time to creative thinking (Ng & Feldman, 2012). Hindrance stressors possess a negative impact on performance regardless of the effort an individual exerts, thus making it much less likely that new ideas will arise (Seery, 2011). Combining COR and the concept of hindrance stressors, Akinola et al. (2019) argued that threat appraisals are associated with constrictive physiological stress responses that allow the excessive release of dopamine in prefrontal regions, so threat physiology actually reduces creativity performance.

A meta-analysis conducted by Eatough et al. (2011) asserted that both role ambiguity and role conflict are hindering stressors that lead to negative job performance. In the hospitality industry, Geng, Liu, Liu, and Feng (2014) asserted that hindrance stress can affect FSEs' creativity negatively in the local restaurant industry; Hon et al. (2013) also indicated that hindrance stress has a negative impact on hotel employees' creativity. Because role conflict increases the cognitive perception of incompatible job expectations, FSEs experiencing role conflict may feel threatened by the risk of resource loss and a subsequent resource-depleting experience, which may be accompanied by significant threat physiological responses. In order to prevent this loss of resources, role conflict might therefore inhibit employee creativity (Montani, Setti, Sommovigo,) as FSEs may limit the resources they devote to their work engagement, reducing the level of employee creativity (Gichohi, 2014). Role ambiguity can be related to the deficiency of role clarity, referring to the extent to which an individual obtains and realizes information about his or her job requirements (Knight, Kim, & Crutsinger, 2007). It seems logical to assume that if FSEs feel uncertainty or lack adequate information about what is expected of them and how to perform their jobs, FSEs tend to experience frustration at work (Coelho et al., 2011; De Clercq, 2019). Uncertainties such as unclear job descriptions may cause FSEs to suffer from energy depletion and threat physiological responses (Akinola et al., 2019; De Clercq,

2019). When FSEs experience frustration due to this lack of role clarity, they will also tend to minimize the associated depletion of their resources, which will in turn adversely affect their creative behavior (De Clercq, 2019).

As such, this research proposes the following hypotheses:

H1. Role conflict negatively affects FSEs' creativity.

H2. Role ambiguity negatively affects FSEs' creativity.

2.2. Proactive personality and employee creativity

Proactive personality refers to individual's inclination to "scan for opportunities, show initiative, take action, and persevere until they reach closure by bringing about change" (Bateman & Crant, 1993, p. 104). Put differently, a proactive person tends to take the initiative by seeking information, identifying and acting on opportunities, and reshaping the current environment or moving to a more desirable situation (Crant, 1995, 2000) in order to bring about meaningful change in their work environment. On the contrary, non-proactive people prefer to await opportunities passively, and not incline to actively shape their surroundings (Crant, 1995, 2000). Proactive personality is relevant to positive outcomes, including excellent work performance, leader-member exchange, career success, and so forth (Fuller & Marler, 2009).

In comparison with non-proactive FSEs, FSEs with proactive personalities are more likely to exhibit creativity for a number of reasons. First, by their very nature, a proactive personality will use their initiative to change their environment to create a more desirable situation (Fuller & Marler, 2009; Bergeron, Schroeder, & Martinez, 2014). Prior research indicates that proactive employees tend to look for better solutions that go beyond the expectations of their formal responsibilities because they want to reshape their current situations (Crant, 2000). For example, Jiang and Gu (2015) suggested that proactive employees may feel responsibility for change because they gain available resources from the organization, and are expected to be able to use the resources responsibly and make work-related improvements to achieve organizational strategic objectives.

Second, entrepreneurial intention and behavior are more likely to occur for proactive people (Paul, Hermel, & Srivastava, 2017). Creativity requires experimentation, trial and error, or even failure, thus creativity is associated with psychological risk (Powell, 2008). Highly proactive employees can tolerate failure, and are thus willing to take greater risks to explore new pathways (Coelho et al., 2011). This is because they tend to think ahead to evaluate possible outcomes, anticipate possible futures, and act in advance (Jiang & Gu, 2015).

Based on the COR perspective, proactive FSEs who have stronger inner thoughts and feelings are likely to adopt positive strategies as they engage in problem-solving (Bateman & Crant, 1993) and generate new ideas, and as a result, generate further resource gain. The current study therefore proposes the following hypothesis:

H3. Proactive personality positively affects FSEs' creativity.

2.3. Employee creativity and COBSBs

2.3.1. Employee creativity and external representation

External representation involves presenting a positive impression of the firm's image, products, and services to outsiders (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003). Social exchange theory reflects employees' evaluation of rewards from the company (Emerson, 1976) and it has therefore been suggested that social exchange theory should be utilized to investigate why employees' job satisfaction fosters external representation (Bettencourt, Brown, & MacKenzie, 2005; Lages, 2012; Yoo, 2013; Limpitgul & Jirotmontree, 2012). When they experience positive effects from their organizations, FSEs may become more motivated to carry out extra-role behaviors to reciprocate their feeling of satisfaction (Lages,

2012; Yoo, 2013). Barnes, Ponder, and Hopkins (2015) argued that external representation is a form of employee referral that is viewed as the most credible and trustworthy of all information sources. According to Parish, Berry, and Lam (2008), satisfied employees deliver positive word-of-mouth and job satisfaction positively affects employee referrals. In their examination of the employee referral concept, Barnes et al. (2015) confirmed that job satisfaction leads to positive external representation.

Prior research on creativity has shown that creativity improves job satisfaction (Mishra & Shukla, 2012). Kim, Hon, and Crant (2009) found that employees who create new and useful ideas tend to improve their job environment and therefore experience job satisfaction. Combining these arguments, this study assumes that while FSEs experience job satisfaction originating from their creativity, they may increase their referral intention, and thus enhance the image of the firm through FSEs' advocacy of the firm's products or services. Thus this present research proposes the following hypothesis:

H4a. FSEs' creativity positively affects external representation.

2.3.2. Employee creativity and internal influence

Internal influence refers to the degree to which an individual takes the initiative in sharing information and communicating with their colleagues and the organization as a whole regarding changes in methods or processes that lead to service improvements (Bettencourt et al., 2005). In this context, FSEs, as important boundary spanners, can be viewed as information processing units and critical buffers that confirm whether a proposed change will benefit the organization or not (Andersen & Kragh, 2015). Thus, Woisetschlager, Hanning, and Backhaus (2016, p. 110) redefined internal influence as "disseminating information about creative solutions to customer problems and suggesting possible service improvements". They went on to suggest that frontline employees with internal influence may gather creative ideas during their interactions with customers and then engage in idea dissemination in the company.

Following this logic, as filters or gatekeepers of information, creative FSEs may provide novel and useful ideas regarding customer needs and possible amendments in service delivery to the company (Woisetschlager et al., 2016; Bettencourt et al., 2005). Karlsson and Skälén (2015) explored how frontline employees can become involved in the innovative team, contributing their customer, product and practice knowledge to support service innovation. As part of this process, FSEs can internally disseminate information within the organization, which implies that the employees share and communicate their creative ideas with their co-workers and then make suggestions about further improvements in service delivery. As such, this study proposes the following hypothesis:

H4b. FSEs' creativity positively affects internal influence.

2.3.3. Employee creativity and service delivery

Service delivery is based on job descriptions in which employees are required to serve customers in a conscientious, responsive, flexible, and courteous manner (Bettencourt et al., 2005). Service delivery behavior is viewed as a key element of service quality provision that influences customer relationship quality and customer satisfaction (Yoo, Arnold, & Frankwick, 2014).

However, when the standard available scripts are insufficient to solve customer problems, frontline employees may instead deploy more creative strategies to satisfy customers' needs and attain a higher level of role-prescribed performance. For example, creative FSEs may create new ways to deal with customer problems and complaints, developing new procedures that support the delivery of better service (Geng et al., 2014), make immediate improvements to successfully meet customers' expectations, and provide high-quality customer service for hospitality management (Coelho et al., 2011). Employee creativity positively affects role-prescribed customer service performance (Liu, Liu, & Geng,

2013) and improves marketing performance because new service concepts can meet customer needs and build customers' trust in new services (Yang et al., 2016). As such, this study proposes the following hypothesis:

H4c. FSEs' creativity positively affects service delivery.

2.3.4. Employee creativity, internal influence, and service delivery

Internal market orientation involves obtaining and circulating intelligence of employee needs and then responding appropriately to these needs (Lings & Greenley, 2005). Based on the concept of internal market orientation, this research assumes that employees with internal influence are likely to improve their service delivery. According to Lings and Greenley (2010), enacting appropriate internal market responses enables employees to deliver a service more effectively, especially when followed by organizational strategies that enhance employee identification with the organization, thus fostering employees' in-role behavior. Tortosa, Moliner, and Sánchez (2009) asserted that frontline employees' perceptions of internal market orientation have a positive impact on the quality of service perceived by external customers. Internal influence is considered to be a relatively extra-role activity due to its discretionary nature, but service delivery behavior is viewed as being more role-prescribed because it is likely to be specified in employees' job descriptions (Bettencourt et al., 2005). FSEs' organizational citizen behavior may lead to altruistic behaviors that then foster a higher level of service delivery behavior (Netemeyer, Boles, McKee, & McMurrian, 1997).

Therefore, given this background, it is posited that FSEs' internal influence affects service delivery positively. Further, as discussed previously, FSEs' service delivery and internal influence are outcomes of FSEs' creativity, suggesting that internal influence mediates the link between employee creativity and service delivery. This research therefore proposed the following hypotheses:

H5. FSEs' internal influence positively affects service delivery.

H6. FSEs' internal influence mediates the relationship between employee creativity and service delivery.

3. Methodology

3.1. Data collection

This study collected data from FSEs in international hotels in Taiwan to test the research hypotheses. There were 79 international hotels in Taiwan in September 2019 (Tourism Bureau, 2019). The human resource managers of all 79 hotels were contacted and asked if they would be willing to help collecting the data for this research; 25 agreed to do so. Thirty questionnaires were sealed in envelopes and sent to those human resource managers at 25 international hotels (750 sealed questionnaires in total). Then the managers distributed questionnaires to their FSEs and FSEs returned the completed questionnaires in another sealed envelope to his/her managers for sending them back to us. The incentives of gift certificates (150 NTDs) were provided to thank to respondents of this study and a 1000 NTDs worth gift certificate was given to each manager for appreciating his/her kind assistance. Research data were collected from October 15th to December 15th in 2019. 382 valid samples were collected, for a response rate of 50.9%. The responses of the late respondents (51 persons) were compared to those of the early respondents (332 persons) to examine non-response bias. The results showed no differences in any variable and hence non-response bias is unlikely to be a problem (Armstrong & Overton, 1977). The final sample consisted of 249 female (65.2%) and 133 male (34.8%) staff. Of these, 29.3% were below 30 years of age, and 23.8% were aged 41–50. Most respondents were under 5 years of tenure (39.5%) and 51.8% had a university degree.

3.2. Measures

All measures were developed and/or adapted based on previous research. For role ambiguity and role conflict, a 6-item scale (3 items each) from Rizzo, House, and Lirtzman (1970) was employed. The measurement items also were adopted in the hotel setting (e.g. Karatepe, 2010). A 3-item scale from Seibert, Kraimer, and Crant (2001) was utilized to assess proactive personality. The measurement items also were adopted in the hospitality industry (e.g. Horng et al., 2016). For the measure of employee creativity, Zhou and George's (2001) 4-item scale from was employed. Studies in the hospitality industry such as Hon et al. (2013) have used the measurement items. For the measure of COBSB, this research used a 9-item scale from Bettencourt et al. (2005); internal influence, external representation, and service delivery were assessed with 3 items each. The measurement items also were used in the hospitality industry (e.g. Jung & Yoon, 2020). A 7-point Likert scale, ranging from 1 for "strongly disagree" to 7 for "strongly agree" was used in all scales. A pre-test with a sample of 50 hotel FSEs was conducted before collecting data formally. The pre-test results confirmed the Cronbach's α value of each variable was greater than 0.6 and thus measurements for all variables were deemed reliable.

3.3. Common method variance

The empirical results of this research might be affected by common method variance (CMV) since data were collected employing self-report questionnaires. The Harman's one-factor test was thus utilized to test this threat (Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Lee, & Podsakoff, 2003). The fit indices of the one-factor model are as the following: $\chi^2(209) = 2324.79$, $p < .001$, GFI = 0.64; AGFI = 0.56; RMR = 0.19, indicating a poor model fit. The significant chi-square change ($\Delta\chi^2(21) = 1852.3$, $p < .001$) showed that the seven-factor model used for this research had a better fit than the single-factor model tested. The results suggest that CMV was not an issue for this study.

Table 1
Confirmatory factor analysis results.

Latent and observed variables	Mean	Sd	Std loading	t-Statistic	CR	AVE	α
Role Conflict (RC)					0.622	0.354	0.619
"I receive assignments without adequate resources and materials to complete them".	3.61	1.272	0.596	9.950			
"I receive incompatible requests from two or more people".	3.46	1.126	0.579	9.724			
"I have to buck a rule or policy in order to carry out some assignments".	2.99	1.306	0.610	10.273			
Role Ambiguity (RA)					0.799	0.574	0.777
"I have clear, planned goals and objectives for my job".(R)	2.65	1.260	0.781	16.079			
"I know what my responsibilities are".(R)	2.79	1.248	0.859	18.073			
"I know exactly what is expected of me".(R)	3.15	1.472	0.611	12.124			
Proactive Personality(PP)					0.900	0.752	0.894
"I am constantly on the lookout for new ways to improve my life".	3.03	1.318	0.880	20.968			
"I can spot a good opportunity long before others can".	2.92	1.200	0.965	24.225			
"If I see something I don't like, I fix it".	2.62	1.124	0.741	16.532			
Employee Creativity (EC)					0.843	0.557	0.839
"I come up with new and practical ideas to solve problems".	5.57	0.972	0.747	15.942			
"I search out new technologies, processes, techniques, and/or service ideas".	5.34	1.001	0.850	19.294			
"I suggest new ways to increase/improve quality".	5.32	0.969	0.809	18.013			
"I come up with creative solutions to problems".	5.61	0.948	0.611	12.206			
External Representation (ER)					0.874	0.699	0.871
"I tell outsiders my hotel is a great place to work".	5.58	0.997	0.832	19.259			
"I generate favorable good will for my hotel".	5.69	0.957	0.882	20.987			
"I say good thing about my hotel to others".	5.76	0.940	0.791	17.779			
Internal Influence (II)					0.873	0.697	0.872
"I make constructive suggestions for service improvement".	5.62	0.998	0.784	17.630			
"I share creative solutions to customers' problems with other team members".	5.69	0.966	0.881	21.078			
"I encourage coworkers to contribute ideas and suggestions for service improvement".	5.76	0.940	0.837	19.462			
Service Delivery (SD)					0.880	0.709	0.876
"I follow up in a timely manner to customer requests and problems".	5.80	0.902	0.791	17.803			
"Regardless of circumstances, I show exceptionally courteous and respectful to customers".	5.83	0.874	0.886	21.266			
"I follow through in a conscientious manner on promises to customers".	5.80	0.928	0.847	19.879			

Note. (R) means a reverse-coded item. Goodness-of-fit: $\chi^2/df = 2.513$, RMR = 0.059, RMSEA = 0.063, NFI = 0.906, IFI = 0.941, TLI = 0.927, CFI = 0.941, and GFI = 0.90. α : Cronbach's alpha., AVE: average variance extracted, Sd: Standard Deviation, CR: composite reliability, Std loading: Standardized loading.

4. Results

4.1. Scale validity and reliability

Whether or not items of questions in the survey questionnaire appropriately stand for the latent variables can be tested by conducting a confirmatory factor analysis. Amos 21.0 was therefore used to test reliability and validity of the latent variables. As shown in Table 1, $\chi^2/df = 2.513$, RMSEA = 0.063, RMR = 0.059, and IFI, NFI, TLI, CFI, GFI were all greater than 0.90, confirming that an acceptable model fit was obtained for the overall measurement model (Hu & Bentler, 1999).

A Cronbach's α value ranging from 0.5 to 0.7 is acceptable and over 0.7 indicates high reliability, according to Nunnally (1978). The Cronbach's α value for each variables was above 0.6 (see Table 1), suggesting that the questionnaire used in this research was acceptably reliable. The factor loadings for all the observed items and their latent variables were also calculated. As illustrated in Table 1, all factor loadings were greater than 0.50, indicating a good item reliability (Hair, Black, Babin, & Anderson, 2010). Additionally, Composite reliability (CR) and average variance extracted (AVE) were used to assess internal consistency. CR and AVE values should be above 0.60 and 0.50, respectively (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). CR and AVE values of this research, as shown in Table 1, met the requirements except for role conflict (AVE = 0.354), indicating an appropriate internal consistency. Discriminant validity was assessed by comparing the square of the correlation parameters with the AVE value. The square root of the AVE value of every variable is greater than the inter-construct correlations (Hair et al., 2010), as shown in Table 2, indicating a good discriminant validity and that variables are distinct from one another.

4.1.1. Hypotheses testing

Structural equation modeling (SEM) was utilized for hypotheses testing. The estimated model was illustrated in Fig. 1, showing the direction and magnitude of the impact of the standardized path coefficients. The fit indices were as below: $\chi^2 = 508.44$, $df = 198$ ($\chi^2/df =$

Table 2
Correlation matrix and average variance extracted.

Variable	Mean	Sd	RC	RA	PP	EC	ER	II	SD
RC	3.35	0.93	0.595						
RA	2.86	1.11	0.469**	0.758					
PP	2.88	1.10	-0.055	-0.003	0.867				
EC	5.68	0.86	-0.267**	-0.304**	0.124*	0.760			
ER	5.46	0.80	-0.368**	-0.391**	0.083	0.476**	0.836		
II	5.63	0.88	-0.311**	-0.368**	0.049	0.669**	0.564**	0.835	
SD	5.81	0.81	-0.287**	-0.374**	-0.174**	0.669**	0.503**	0.694**	0.842

Note. N = 382. Inter-construct correlations is shown off the diagonal; square root of average variance extracted (AVE) is shown on the diagonal of the matrix; Sd: Standard Deviation; ** $p < .01$.

RC = Role Conflict, RA = Role Ambiguity, PP=Proactive Personality, EC = Employee Creativity, ER = External Representation, II=Internal Influence, SD=Service Delivery.

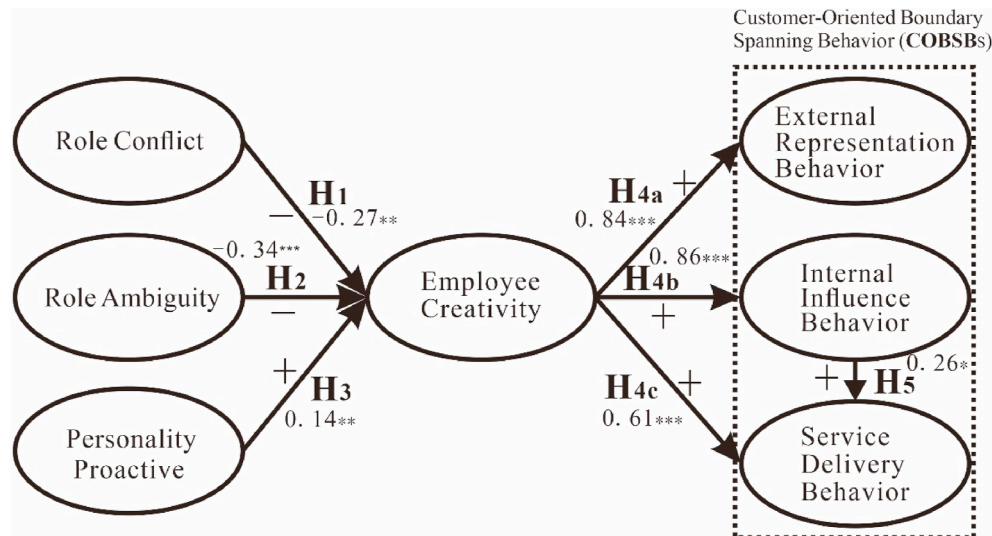


Fig. 1. Structural path estimates mode. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

2.568), RMSEA = 0.064, RMR = 0.062, NFI = 0.899, IFI = 0.936, TLI = 0.924, CFI = 0.935, and GFI = 0.984. This result can be accepted and the research model's overall fit is reached (Hu & Bentler, 1999).

The hypotheses were tested by the estimation of causal path parameters and the results are presented in Table 3. Role conflict as well as role ambiguity have significant negative impacts on employee creativity ($\beta = -0.27$, $p < .01$, $\beta = -0.34$, $p < .001$, respectively). Thus H1 and H2 were confirmed. Proactive personality positively affects employee creativity ($\beta = 0.14$, $p < .01$); hence H3 was confirmed. Employee creativity positively affects external representation ($\beta = 0.84$, $p < .001$), internal influence ($\beta = 0.86$, $p < .001$), and service delivery ($\beta = 0.61$, $p < .001$); hence H4a, H4b, and H4c were also confirmed. Finally, internal influence positively affects service delivery ($\beta = 0.26$, $p < .05$),

confirming H5.

4.1.2. The mediation effect of internal influence

As shown in Fig. 2, our model also specifies that internal influence mediates the link between FSEs' creativity and service delivery. While the results provide some support for the indirect effect of employee creativity on service delivery, the direct effect suggests that the mediating role of internal influence is only 'partial' since the direct effect of employee creativity on service delivery ($\beta_{\text{direct}} = 0.16$, $p < .05$) remains significant after the inclusion of the mediating effect ($\beta_{\text{indirect}} = 0.766$, $p < .001$).

Table 3
Path coefficients and their significance.

Hypotheses	Path	Standardized path coefficient	t Statistic	Result
H ₁	RC→EC	-0.27**	-2.57	Support
H ₂	RA→EC	-0.34***	-3.67	Support
H ₃	PP→EC	0.14**	2.72	Support
H _{4a}	EC→ER	0.84***	9.27	Support
H _{4b}	EC→II	0.86***	8.10	Support
H _{4c}	EC→SD	0.61***	4.28	Support
H ₅	II→SD	0.26*	2.12	Support

Notes: * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

RC = Role Conflict, RA = Role Ambiguity, PP=Proactive Personality, EC = Employee Creativity, ER = External Representation, II=Internal Influence, SD=Service Delivery.

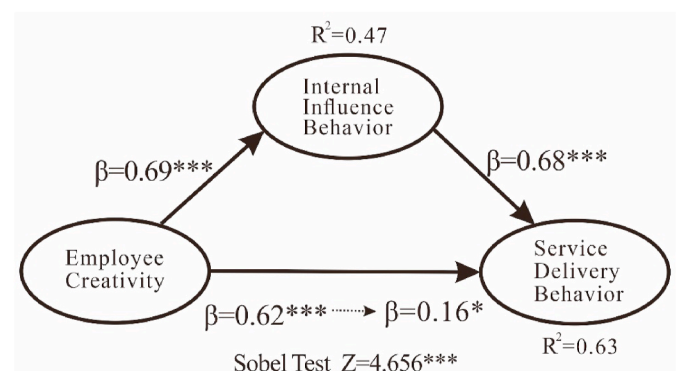


Fig. 2. Results of the mediation analyses. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

5. Discussion and conclusion

Several meaningful contributions are provided in the present research. First, the research results indicate that role conflict and role ambiguity should be viewed as hindering stressors that limit the resources available for engaging in creative activities through a resource depletion process. On the other hand, a proactive person invests personal resources in creative activities through an active motivational process. These findings are in line with COR and JD-R model. With regard to role stress, the study's findings confirm the negative influence of role conflict and role ambiguity on employee creativity. This is consistent with previous studies which assert role conflict (e.g. Wang, Huang, Davison, & Yang, 2020) and role ambiguity (e.g. Coelho et al., 2011) negatively affect employee creativity. Hon and Lui (2016) contended that time pressure and workload hinder employee creativity in the hospitality industry. These results extend Hou and Liu's (2016) work and suggest that role conflict and role ambiguity can also be obstacles to FSEs' creativity in the hotel industry. These findings also confirm that proactive personality directly improves employee creativity, which is in accordance with previous research (e.g. Kim, Hon, & Crant, 2009). Because FSEs with higher proactive personality traits actively look for opportunities of improving their current environments, they are most likely to be the ones who come up with new ideas.

Second, this study focused on a specific and detailed examination of how FSEs' creativity affects COBSBs. Although past research has suggested that employee creativity leads to positive individual and organizational outcomes (Hon & Lui, 2016), no evidence had been presented to show conclusively that employee creativity leads to COBSBs. The research results provide this evidence and confirm that FSEs' creativity positively affects external representation, internal influence, and service delivery. When FSEs serve their customers in a creative way, they deliver excellent service that satisfies customers, gaining a better external impression from the customers, and take the initiative in communicating information about improvements in service delivery to their co-workers and organizations. In particular, the research findings confirm that internal influence has a mediation effect between employee creativity and service delivery. These findings also reveal that employee creativity improves role-prescribed behaviors (service delivery) through extra-role behaviors (internal influence). Thus, the present study adds new knowledge to employee creativity literature by extending the consideration of COBSBs as consequences of FSEs' creativity in the hospitality setting.

5.1. Managerial implications

The hotel industry is a high-contact service industry, where service quality and customer satisfaction depend on FSEs' customer-oriented behavior (Barnes et al., 2015; Hon & Lui, 2016). Faced with increasingly competitive environments, customer-oriented hotel firms must put customers' interest first, highlighting the need for their FSEs to actively seek out new ways to satisfy their customers. Boosting FSEs' creativity may generate beneficial customer-oriented behavior such as better external representation, internal influence, and service delivery. Especially, FSEs' creativity affects service delivery through internal influence. Internal influence focuses on sharing, communicating, and disseminating information with both the organization and their co-workers when suggesting possible service improvements. Karlsson and Skålen (2015) argued that frontline employees who have been involved in developing an improvement in service delivery can internally disseminate information on the new service to their co-workers and facilitate its market launch. Thus, hotel managers may foster the development of FSEs internal influence.

If managers are to encourage creativity among their FSEs effectively, they need to understand what obstructs and facilitates this creativity. First, the results suggest that role conflict and role ambiguity often undermine employees' creativity. If employees are uncertain of their job

expectations and requirement, or experience role incongruities, they tend to focus on meeting performance standards and preventing resource loss, avoiding the need to come up with new ways to solve customer problems. In order to decrease role ambiguity and role conflict, hotel managers may empower FSEs to revise some job descriptions under the company's policy, and provide training programs in communication skills for minimizing problems related with role conflict (Karatepe, 2010). Second, our findings suggest that a proactive personality may improve employee creativity. The hospitality industry needs proactive employees who are passionate about their work if it is to be able to cope with diverse and rapidly changing customer demands (Horng et al., 2016). Thus, organizations may consider reviewing the selection procedures they utilize to assess job applicants and hire more proactive candidates from the labor market.

5.2. Limitations and future research

Some limitations of this research should be noticed. First, this study examined the relationships among role stress, proactive personality, employee creativity, and COBSBs. However, this study used cross-sectional data and was unable to establish causality given that the data are not experimental or longitudinal in nature. Future research could consider employ experiments and provide additional insights by exploring the potentially moderating and mediating effects of other factors such as person-job fit, work engagement. Second, self-reporting scales were used to measure role stress, proactive personality, creativity, and COBSBs, as perceived by the FSEs who participated in the study. Harman's one-factor test result suggests that CMV is not an issue for the current study; however, perceptions of supervisors and customers can be included in future research. Third, women comprise the majority of FSEs in the hotel sector in Taiwan (Buffon Digital and Technology, 2019); future studies could explore the different impacts due to gender among the variables. Fourth, the data for this study was collected in the hospitality industry in Taiwan, raising the question of generalizability of the findings to firms in other industries and countries. Thus, testing this model in different service settings or in different countries would increase its generalizability.

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